



18th century found an intrinsic value in the difference between the past and the present. The Romantics drew inspiration from the Middle Ages, and instead of seeing the past as a preparation for the modern world, Romantic historians tried the imaginative exercise of entering into the spirit of past ages. Much of this was associated with nationalism. The German Romantic thinker Johann Gottfried Herder (1774–1803) burrowed into the past in search of roots of national identity and an authentic “German spirit.” As nationalism triumphed in Europe in the 19th century, much of history became a celebration of national characteristics and national heroes. Every country wanted to have its sacred heroic history, just as it had its flag and its national anthem.

The “Grand Narrative”

In the 19th century, history became increasingly important and took on the quality of destiny. Arrogantly, European civilization saw itself as the goal to which all history had been progressing and constructed narratives that made sense of the past in those terms. The German philosopher Georg Wilhelm Friedrich Hegel (1770–1831) articulated a grand scheme of history as a logical development, which culminated in the end point of the Prussian state. Philosopher and social revolutionary Karl Marx (1818–1883) later adapted Hegel’s scheme into his own theory (“historical materialism”), in which he claimed that economic progress, which caused conflict between the social classes, would inevitably

one day result in the proletariat seizing power from the bourgeoisie, while the capitalist world order collapsed under its own inner contradictions. Arguably, Marxism was to prove the most influential and durable of all historical “grand narratives.”

Like other areas of knowledge, in the 19th century history underwent professionalization and became an academic discipline. Academic history aspired to the status of a science, and the accumulation of “facts” was its avowed purpose. A gap opened up between “serious” history—often heavy on economic statistics—and the colorful literary works of popular historians, such as Jules Michelet (1798–1874) and Thomas Macaulay (1800–1859).

The rise of social history

In the 20th century, the subject matter of history—which had always focused on kings, queens, prime ministers, presidents, and generals—increasingly expanded to embrace the common people, whose role in historical events became accessible through more in-depth research. Some historians chose to disregard the “history of events” altogether, preferring instead to study social structures and the patterns of everyday life, beliefs, and ways of thinking (“mentalités”) of ordinary people in different historical periods.

A Eurocentric approach

Until the second half of the 20th century, most world history was written as the story of the triumph of Western civilization. This approach was as implicit in Marxist versions